

“ IN ISLAM, THE LEGISLATIVE POWER AND COMPETENCE TO ESTABLISH LAWS BELONG EXCLUSIVELY TO GOD. ”

Ayatollah Khomeini, from his lectures on Islamic Government

Iranian women holding posters of Ayatollah Khomeini show support for the Islamic Revolution. Mass demonstrations brought the country to a halt.



20:1 War casualties
Afghans paid a heavy price for the Soviet invasion—for every Soviet who was killed or wounded, 20 Afghan soldiers lost their lives.

VIETNAMESE FORCES ENTERED CAMBODIA in 1978, in response to repeated border attacks by the **Khmer Rouge** (see 1978). On January 7, 1979, they seized the Cambodian capital of **Phnom Penh** and the Khmer Rouge were driven from power. **Pol Pot**, leader of the Khmer Rouge, fled to the jungle in Thailand and began a **guerrilla war** against a succession of Cambodian governments. On April 2, Vietnamese forces discovered a **mass grave** in the northeast—this was the first of many mass graves from the Pol Pot era to be discovered. It became apparent that between 1975 and 1979 Pol Pot was responsible for the slaughter of more than 1 million people.

Rings of Jupiter
An image taken by NASA's Voyager 2 spacecraft shows Jupiter's ring system, never seen before, being bombarded by tiny meteorites.

China viewed the Vietnamese attack on Cambodia as a serious provocation, and, on February 17, Chinese forces **invaded Vietnam**. Casualties on both sides were high, and each side claimed to have won the upper hand.

When **Afghan communists** took power through a coup in 1978, they found themselves pulled three ways: between the **Soviets**, the **Americans**, and the Islamic regime in **Iran**. In March, a resistance group declared a **holy war** against the “godless” Marxist regime and killed Soviet citizens in Herat, western Afghanistan. In the countryside, revolt grew against repressive government initiatives, and the Afghan army faced total collapse. In light of this, the Soviet Union feared an Iranian-style **Islamist revolution**. Citing the 1978 Treaty of Friendship, the **Soviets invaded**

Afghanistan on December 24. In doing so, they were confident of military superiority. However, the US had been covertly training anti-government forces, the **Mujahideen** (warriors), and the Soviets were met with fierce resistance when they stormed into Kabul.

As the political situation in **Iran** deteriorated (see 1978), the **Shah** was forced into exile. **Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini** (1902–89), a Shi'ite Muslim cleric, returned from 15 years of exile to jubilant crowds, and the **Islamic Republic of Iran** was proclaimed on April 1. Western influences were suppressed, and many who had been educated in the West fled the country. Young supporters of



AK-47 Kalashnikov assault rifle
The AK-47 became an iconic weapon during the Soviet war in Afghanistan. Used by both sides, Kalashnikovs were cheap and readily available.

Ayatollah Khomeini, angered by America's long support of the Shah, took control of the US embassy in **Tehran**. They seized 63 hostages, and vowed not to release them until the US returned the Shah for trial. In response, **President Carter embargoed Iranian oil**. Female and non-US citizen hostages were released, and then a male hostage who became seriously ill, in 1980, but 52 Americans remained hostage until 1981.

The left-wing **Sandinista National Liberation Front** succeeded in overthrowing the US-backed regime in the republic of **Nicaragua** and took the capital, Managua. This ended seven years of civil war against the **Somoza** government. The Sandinistas established a revolutionary government on July 20, led by **Daniel and Humberto Ortega**.

Both the Irish Republican Army (**IRA**) and the Irish National Liberation Army (**INLA**) were active

this year. On March 30, shadow Northern Ireland secretary **Airey Neave** was killed by an **INLA** car bomb. On August 27, **Lord Louis Mountbatten** (a member of the British royal family) was killed by an **IRA** bomb blast. Hours later, 18 soldiers were killed in booby-trap bomb explosions close to the border with the Irish Republic. The deaths unleashed a series of civilian killings.

Ugandan leader Idi Amin (1925–2003) was forced to flee the capital city of Kampala on April 11 as Tanzanian troops, along with exiles and the **Uganda National Liberation Front**, closed in. Two days later, Kampala fell and a coalition government took power. **Yusufu Lule** (1912–85), who had been driven into exile by Amin, became president. Amin escaped to Libya, leaving behind a country with its economy in tatters.

The **Sony Walkman** was launched in **Japan** on June 22. The first Walkman featured a cassette player and the world's first lightweight headphones. It cost US\$200, and sold out within a month.

